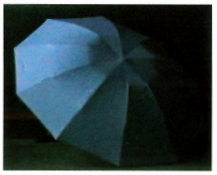

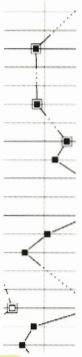

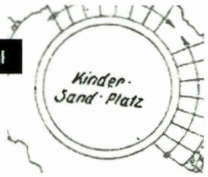

trans magazin
Left

By Hand

For trans 49, let us turn to the left and plunge our feet into the evil, the fragile, the foolish, the useless, the leftover, the alternative – the other side. Turning left can be difficult. Traffic moves at a pace you can't control. It takes waiting for the right moment, it implies being vulnerable and picking up speed, it means looking both ways and being sure of this direction, committing to a new path. Some think this is extreme, others think it's as simple as leaning in.

What derives from the Old English «lyft» is widely considered an objective term for orientation. But leaning in means using the side of the body that has been more unknown. The lyft, the weaker? Or just the unfamiliar, the weird, or the wicked? Who is to say what is deviant and what is straight?

Through my left eye I gain half my vision but if I close my right, I can actually see more. I look at familiar stories from a different perspective. Left-eyed, I notice things that I've never seen before: What have I been missing that has been there in plain sight? What else do I need my left eye to see?

Does turning to the left mean being leftist? The left side gives me strength, lets us question authorities, shows us joyful alternatives. Searching for leftist futures and thinking of ephemeral pasts – are those sitting on the left still advocating for a more radical change?

And, ultimately, what will I leave behind? As the past tense of leave, left points to what stays. Traceable footprints in the physical world and beyond – once appearing to be temporary but what will happen now to these leftovers?

Left is many directions – what is Left of you? What is Left to you?

Charlotte Arn, Burak Alp Kaya, Alexandra Lyn, Simon Zimmermann

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Chapter I: Lyft

Beyond Left and Right: Meanders, Sediments, and Urban Imaginaries

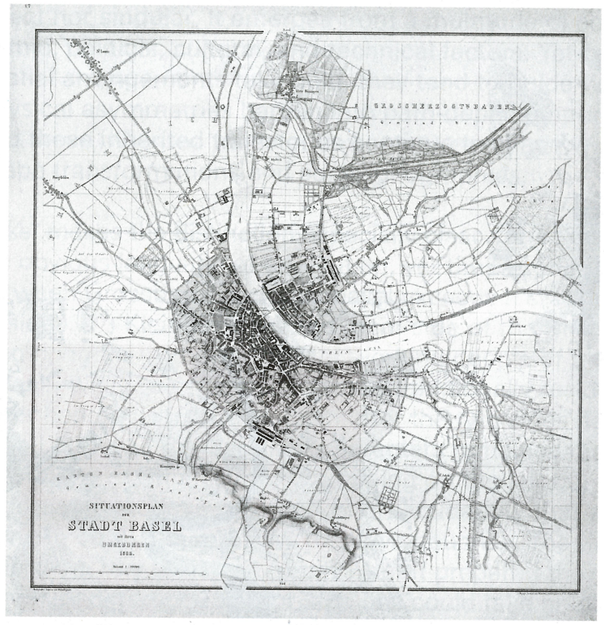
Dennis Häusler

Rivers have established left and right banks, conventionally defined with respect to the direction of flow. On a map, this distinction is reasonable. In the urban landscape, however, another contrast is often more consequential for the organisation of the ground: that between the inner and outer banks of a bend. This is less a matter of orientation than of process. A meander does not simply divide space into two sides; it differentiates terrain through erosion, deposition, drift, and resistance. In that sense, the river can be understood less as a line on a surface than as a line that actively forms the ground it traverses.

In Swiss waterscapes, such relations can still be read on the ground, despite rivers being embanked, canalised, and tightly integrated into infrastructures of transport, flood prevention, and energy production. Despite these layers of cultural history, older fluvial dynamics remain inscribed in the terrain. Whether a river moves across broad deposited ground or cuts into resistant rock, affects the steepness of its banks, the stability of its slopes, the depth of incision, and the kinds of terraces or flood-prone flats that emerge. On the outside of a bend, deeper water and faster currents erode the bank and scour the channel. Inside, the current slows and loses its carrying capacity – it deposits sediment. Over time, this produces a differentiated section: One edge becomes steeper, the other tends to broaden into lower grounds. Before any planner intervenes, the river has already shaped the terrain.

Urbanisation rarely erases such asymmetries. More often, it takes hold of them, as Anne Whiston Spirn argues, cities negotiate with natural processes rather than transcend them. (1) Ground that is easier to stabilise, connect, and build upon often attracts early settlement, transportation infrastructure, and institutional concentration. Lower or more exposed terrain, by contrast, may remain available for uses that require space, tolerate periodic risk, or depend on cheaper land: industry, infrastructure, or segregated housing. Drawing on Robert Smithson's idea of the «sedimentation of the mind», a site can be understood as something that changes over time: Material layers, human perceptions, and cultural meanings are continually reshaped. (2) The relation between fluvial form and urban structure is neither

A



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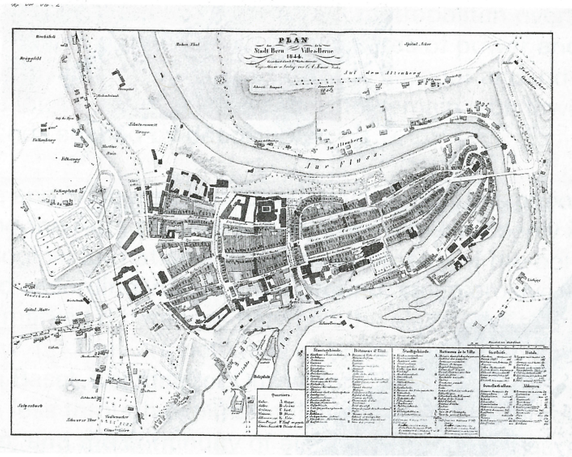

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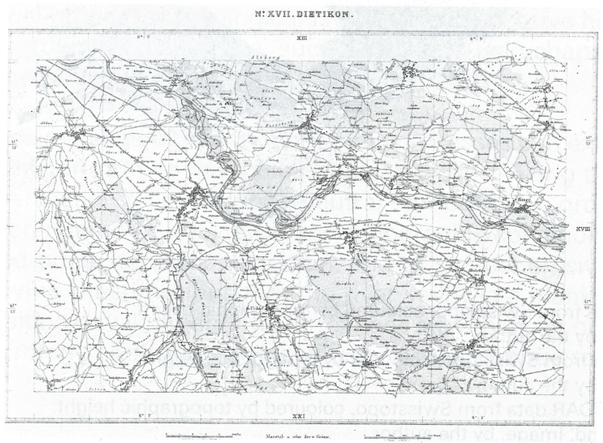


A Historic map of the City of Basel by the Technisches Bureau des Baukollegiums der Stadt Basel, Winterthur: Topogr. Anstalt von Wurster, Randegger & Co., 1868, Universitätsbibliothek Basel

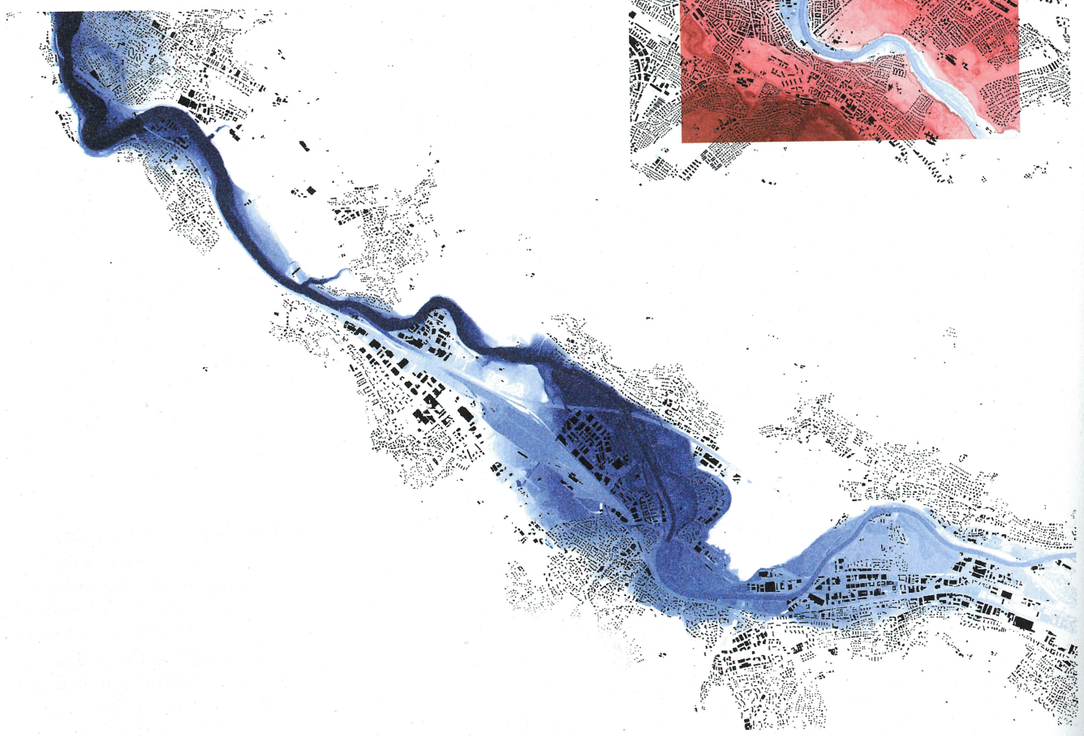
B Historic map of Bern by J.S. Gerster, ed. by Schulbuchhandlung Antenen, Bern, Winterthur: Wurster, Randegger & Cie, 1876, Zentralbibliothek Zürich

C Historic map of the Limmat Valley («Dietikon») by Josef Graf, Zurich: Topographisches Bureau des Kantons Zürich, 1855, ETH Library

D

E

F



D Basel, topographic analysis based on LiDAR data from Swisstopo, coloured by topographic height: blue as low ground, red as high ground. Image: by the author
E Bern, topographic analysis based on LiDAR data from Swisstopo, coloured by topographic height: blue as low ground, red as high ground. Image: by the author
F Limmat Valley, topographic analysis based on LiDAR data from Swisstopo, coloured by topographic height: dark blue as low ground, light blue as high ground. Image: by the author

direct nor singular. It emerges from a multitude of socio-economic, political, cultural, and technical factors. Yet once certain spatial arrangements take hold, they tend to guide what follows. Physical asymmetries harden into path-dependent urban form, and these inherited trajectories continue to shape wider landscape transformations and social geographies.

Basel makes the distinction especially clear – left and right remain the obvious language of orientation, yet the historical difference between Grossbasel and Kleinbasel exceeds a simple opposition of sides. (A) Kleinbasel, on the inner side of the Rhine bend, long counted as the quarter for working people of more modest means, while the wealthier classes traditionally resided on the outer bend in Grossbasel. Even after the two sides had been joined into a single city, their characters remained distinctly different. The example shows that being on the left bank does not necessarily produce the kinds of urban identity that elsewhere came to be associated with the «rive gauche». The river did not determine this social geography, but it prepared the grounds on which different urban trajectories could take hold. (D) Comparable patterns can be observed in other Rhine cities such as Cologne or Düsseldorf, and along metropolitan rivers such as the Thames or the Seine. Historic cores of power and wealth are often located on outer bends, while harbour and industrial zones have long occupied – and often still remain – on lower inner grounds shaped by deposition.

Bern and Fribourg reveal another version of this phenomenon. (B) Along the Aare and the Sarine, the rivers cut deeply into resistant geological formations, and the asymmetry of the bend is intensified accordingly: high inner ground, steep erosive outer edges, and marked differences between the elevated city and the terrain below. (E) They are not cities of broad depositional meanders, as in Basel, Cologne, or Düsseldorf. The river bends shape urban form less through expansive fluvial ground than through incision, slope, and the continuity of elevated terrain. The asymmetry remains, but in a sharper and more vertical form. It is shaped by fluvial processes, geological layers, and successive histories of settlement. Over time, such conditions help shape distinct patterns of occupation and urban meaning.

These readings of hydrotopographic processes can extend beyond the historic city to the scale of the landscape. Along the Limmat, urbanisation followed not a neutral corridor but a ground already differentiated by geological and topographic conditions, by flood-prone depositional terrain, and by steeper erosive edges. (C) Defying presumptions that the river valley is a blank field awaiting development, the terrain has already been organised by hydrology and topography whose traces continue to inform

urbanisation today. Inner bends are often still occupied by agriculture, nature reserves, leisure grounds, or industrial zones, while historic settlements on outer bends continue to extend towards an increasingly controlled river edge as recent developments in Schlieren or Dietikon reveal. Such large-scale patterns are often quieter than the iconic bend of a historic city, but no less formative for the landscapes that emerge. (F)

Marcel Poëte argued that cities evolve in relation to their geographical setting, and that urban form and urban memory develop together. (3) This perspective offers a way of opening urban and landscape imaginaries. It suggests that a river is not just a border between two sides, but an early shaper of differentiated ground, whose first traces continue to inform later settlement, infrastructure, forms of use, and social geographies. Following André Corboz's notion of land as a palimpsest, one might imagine that rivers invite a particular kind of reading, in which fluvial traces and urban imaginaries remain quietly legible through one another. (4) Hydrotopographic distinctions have shaped past development, present occupations, and will likely continue to inform future transformations. Renewed attention to these patterns may help guide planning and landscape architectural practice under conditions of climate change and intensifying landscape dynamics.

Dennis Häusler is an architect and researcher in landscape architecture at ETH Zurich, working on design methodologies for dynamic waterscapes in the Swiss context. His research focuses on a combination of computational, physical, and site-specific design methods across different scales and temporalities.

Something Wicked This Way Comes

Chloe Tsui

«You are the true Hyenas, that allure us with the fairness of your skins and when folly has brought us within your reach, you leap upon us. You are the traitors of Wisdom, the impediment to Industry… The clogs to Virtue and the goads that drive us to all vices, impiety and ruin. You are the Fool's Paradise, the wiseman's Plague, and the Grand Error of Nature.» (1)

In 1486, Heinrich Kramer published «Malleus Maleficarum», a treatise that shaped the social construction of women as witches, portraying them as the primary source of the anxieties that were arising during the rapidly changing times of early modern Europe. As this narrative ran rampant with mania, witches were hunted, tried, and executed for causing unfamiliar, or even «supernatural» harm ranging from ailments to crop failures. Until this moment, witches, and their seemingly «mystical» abilities in midwifery, healing, and agricultural fertility had hardly been a cause for concern.

If one were to dispel the misconceptions surrounding magic and recognise the witches' relations to the earth as grounded knowledge, an alternative account becomes inevitable. Witches were a threat to the doctrine of capitalism given that the making of the modern world demanded the enclosure of land, the extraction of resources, and the control of labour – mandates that stood in direct opposition to the communal autonomy witches maintained. The witch hunts were, therefore, intricately linked to the women who served as the strongest proponents for the preservation of land and stewardship of collective ecological knowledge. (2) Being branded as a witch resulted in numerous associations: the heretic, the healer, the deviant, the enchantress, the wicked.

«Something Wicked This Way Comes» is an archival project that traces the origins of the witch hunt as a mechanism for the act of «othering» used to justify the persecution and displacement of marginalised ethnic and religious groups from land. (3) While there has long been a history of accusations of witchcraft and the execution of witches coeval with the beginnings of the modern era – the colonisation of the New World, the enclosure of the commons, and the transatlantic slave trade, to name a few – this discourse has remained as fragmented folklore for so long that it runs the risk of being forgotten. (4)

This archive is an act of resistance, in some ways an act of heresy, through placing artefacts of the printed page in conversation with one another. The etymology of the page, or «paigna», goes hand in hand with its roots in agricultural practice, that is, «a planted vine, forming a rectangle,» and stemming from the word «pangere», meaning to fix in the ground. (5) From this defined agricultural space, it is understood that the page was more than just a boundary for organising textual information dictated by material constraints, but also acted as the structure necessary for the dissemination of ideologies. The emergence of the Western printing press at the onset of the Renaissance enabled the rapid spread of ideas, and with that, propaganda. Notably, some of the earliest uses of the printing press included the production of pamphlets that proclaimed the dangers posed by witches through plain, sensationalist language for the uneducated masses. (6) Recognising a historical narrative where witch hunts were formative tools in the making of a capitalist society critiques the construction of collective memory, decentralises authority over the past, challenges the sanctity of dominant discourses, and recovers forms of knowledge which are excluded from the collective record. Rather than reducing this history to a single piece of evidence or period, the following archival artefacts are brought into conversation across mediums and time to complicate known and upheld narratives on women's role in the creation of the environment:

John William Waterhouse's painting depicts Medea, the powerful sorceress and talented herbalist, or witch, preparing an ointment containing Henbane for Jason's quest to retrieve the Golden Fleece. Henbane has often been referred to as the «witches plant», having been used since Ancient Egypt for its various hallucinogenic properties. Medea herself has frequently been depicted as vengeful and ruthless, capable of killing in her pursuit of love. The Golden Fleece came from a winged ram, and its ownership had been passed around between rulers, in some ways representative of land itself. Here, the witch Medea may have been the means for this symbolic acquisition of power, but it is important to note that she herself was coerced into helping Jason through Eros' divine intervention of «mad passion». (A)

The «Malleus Maleficarum», translated in English as «The Hammer of Witches», was published in 1486 in Speyer, Germany. It was considered a guide for spotting witches, and recommended torture to obtain confessions. Due to innovations of the printing press,

Menschen sich begegnen, schweigen, warten oder erinnern. Selbst säkularisierte Formen des Abschieds bleiben deshalb auf Räume angewiesen, die Halt, Ordnung oder Rückzug ermöglichen. (6)

Rückblickend erinnere ich mich weniger an die Rituale selbst als an die Räume, in denen getrauert wurde: an das Pflegeheim meines Dorfes, in das wir meine Mutter zum Sterben gebracht hatten; an die kleine Totenkapelle mit dem gekühlten Sarg; an die Kirche, in welcher der Abschiedsgottesdienst stattfand; an das Pfarreilokal, in dem danach Kaffee und Kuchen serviert wurden; und später vor allem an den Friedhof. Um diese Räume mussten wir uns nie kümmern. Sie standen zur Verfügung. Die Institution Kirche organisierte nicht nur das Ritual, sondern auch die Infrastruktur des Abschieds.

Doch kein Ritual und kein Raum konnte die Trauer für mich übernehmen.

Eigentlich habe ich erst richtig getrauert, als es um mich herum ruhiger wurde und das Leben weiterging. Dann bin ich oft allein auf den Friedhof gegangen. Nicht, um zu beten, sondern um einfach dort zu sein. Der Friedhof liegt direkt am Waldrand und gehört zu den wenigen öffentlichen Orten, an denen ich mich allein wohlgefühlt habe. Ein Ort mit eigenen Regeln, eigener Ruhe und einer anderen Zeitlichkeit. Und so kommt es, dass ich den Friedhof trotz meiner teils sehr individuellen Form der Trauer weiterhin als Ort schätze.

Wir unterschätzen, wie körperlich und räumlich Trauer bleibt. Sie braucht Platz, Räume, Orte und Dinge, die bestehen. Nach dem Tod bleiben nicht nur trauernde Menschen zurück, sondern auch Körper, Asche und persönliche Gegenstände, die aufgehoben werden müssen.

Viele Formen des Abschieds wurden lange von religiösen Strukturen getragen. Wenn diese wegfallen, entsteht nicht nur eine rituelle, sondern auch eine räumliche Leere. Der Umgang damit liegt zunehmend bei uns selbst.

Was passiert, wenn Trauer nicht mehr selbstverständlich an feste Orte gebunden ist? Immer häufiger findet Abschied ausserhalb klassischer Friedhöfe statt. Aschen werden im Wald verstreut, an Seen beigesetzt oder privat aufbewahrt. (7)

Darin zeigt sich nicht nur der Wunsch nach Individualität, sondern auch eine Sehnsucht nach Orten, die nicht institutionell vorgegeben sind. Wälder, Berge oder Gewässer wirken für viele Menschen unmittelbarer als die Räume der Kirche.

Dabei ist die Verbindung von Tod, Erinnerung und Landschaft keineswegs neu. Lange bevor kirchliche Friedhöfe und Sakralräume zu den zentralen Orten des Abschieds wurden, waren Bestattungs- und Erinnerungspraktiken vielerorts eng mit der natürlichen Umgebung verknüpft. Die heutige Hinwendung zu Wäldern, Bergen oder Gewässern wirkt weniger wie etwas grundlegend Neues als vielmehr wie das Wiederauftauchen einer Beziehung, die nie ganz verschwunden ist.

Vielleicht verschwindet mit der Säkularisierung nicht das Bedürfnis nach Ritualen, sondern nur die Selbstverständlichkeit ihrer Institutionen.

Maria Gisler, geboren 2001, studiert Architektur an der ETH Zürich. Janna Muff, geboren 2000, studierte Soziologie und Ethik an der Universität Luzern. Beide stammen aus der Zentralschweiz und interessieren sich dafür, wie gesellschaftlicher Wandel Räume, Traditionen und Rituale verändert.

Notes

P. 8 BEYOND LEFT AND RIGHT: MEANDERS, SEDIMENTS, AND URBAN IMAGINARIES
Dennis Häusler

(1) Anne Whiston Spirn, The Granite Garden: Urban Nature and Human Design, New York 1984, here p. 5.
(2) Robert Smithson, «A Sedimentation of the Mind: Earth Projects», Artforum 7, no. 1 (1968), pp. 44–50, here p. 45.
(3) Marcel Poëte, Introduction à l'urbanisme: L'évolution des villes, la leçon de l'Antiquité, Paris 1967 [1929]. pp. 2–8.
(4) Corboz, André. «The Land as Palimpsest», Diogenes, 31, no. 121 (1983), pp. 12–34.

P. 13 SOMETHING WICKED THIS WAY COMES
Chloe Tsui

(1) Walter Charleton, «Ephesian Matron», 1659, p. 71.
(2) This work is rooted in Silvia Federici's groundbreaking piece «Caliban and the Witch: Women, the Body, and Primitive Accumulation», London 2004.
(3) Merriam-Webster defines a witch hunt as 1) A searching out for persecution of persons accused of witchcraft and 2) More Broadly, the searching out and deliberate harassment of those (such as political opponents) with unpopular views.
(4) This work is not meant to be palatable; it is meant to cause trouble. I am taking up Donna Haraway's task to, «make trouble, to stir up potent response to devastating events as well as to settled troubled waters and rebuild quiet places.» Donna J. Haraway, Staying with the Trouble: Making Kin in the Chthulucene, Durham, 2016, p. 1.
(5) Emmanuël Souchier, «Histoires de pages et pages d'histoire», in: L'aventure des écritures: La page, Paris 1999, pp. 19–55, here p. 20.
(6) Carla Suhr, «Publishing for the Masses: Early Modern English Witchcraft Pamphlets», Neuphilologische Mitteilungen 113, no.1 (2012), pp. 118–121, http://www.jstor.org/stable/43344555.
(7) Federici, Caliban and the Witch (see note 2), p. 101.
(8) K. W. Payne, «Witch in N.Y.», The Tacoma Times, 6 April 1915, https://www.loc.gov/item/sn88085187/1915-04-06/ed-1/.

P. 17 TRACES IN MOVING LAND
Elon Rachamin

(1) Global Volcanism Program, «Report on Hakoneyama (Japan)», Bulletin of the Global Volcanism Network, Smithsonian Institution, https://doi.org/10.5479/si.GVP.BGVN201604-283020 (last modified: April 2016).
(2) «Hakone History», Hakone Japan, https://hakone-japan.com/discover/national-park/basic-information/hakone-history/ (last modified: 13 February 2021).
(3) Owakudani's famous sulphur eggs, or «kuro-tamago», are chicken eggs boiled in the valley's mineral-rich hot springs at 80° C for 60 minutes and steamed at 100° C for 15 minutes. Eating one of these eggs is said to add seven years to your life.
(4) Nobuo Geshi and Jun'ichi Itoh, «Pyroclastic Density Currents Associated with the 2015 Phreatomagmatic Eruption of the Kuchinoerabujima Volcano», Earth, Planets and Space 70 (2018), https://doi.org/10.1186/s40623-018-0881-x.

P. 29 HIGH WALL, RESIDUAL HUM
Taewoo Kim

(1) Pierre Bélanger and Alexander Arroyo, Ecologies of Power: Countermapping the Logistical Landscapes and Military Geographies of the U.S. Department of Defense, Cambridge, MA 2016, pp. 13–49.
(2) Hwang Taejin, «Militarized Landscapes of Yongsan: From Japanese Imperial to Little Americas in Early Cold War Korea», Korea Journal 58, no. 1 (2018), pp. 121–149, here p. 128.
(3) Centres and peripheries are mutually constitutive: a periphery is not natural or pre-existing space, but a relational territory produced by, and in service to, the same urbanising forces that produce the centre. Christian Schmid, «The Urbanization of the Territory: On the Research Approach of ETH Studio Basel», in: Roger Diener et al. (eds.), Territory: On the Development of Landscape and City, Zurich 2016, pp. 22–48, here pp. 39–40.
(4) The phrase «different people's garden» is a common colloquial gloss on the name; the documented scholarly reading of the hanja «異胎院», tied to an account of the Imjin War (1592–1598) in which Japanese soldiers are said to have assaulted Buddhist nuns at a temple near the site, is «village for being pregnant with a foreigner's child». Hunam Yun, «Translation and Fragmented Cities: Focus on Itaewon, Seoul», translation 7 (2018), pp. 32–49, here pp. 36–37.
(5) Hwang Taejin, «Militarized Landscapes of Yongsan» (see note 2), p. 128.
(6) R.R. Krishnan, «Early History of U.S. Imperialism in Korea», Social Scientist 10, no. 3 (1982), pp. 3–18, here p. 15.
(7) United States Forces Korea, The SOFA and You, Yongsan 2016, https://www.usfk.mil/portals/105/documents/sofa/i_20160425_the_sofa_and_you.pdf.
(8) Eun-Young Lee, «The Rhetorical Landscape of Itaewon: Negotiating New Transcultural Identities in South Korea», PhD diss., Bowling Green State University, OH, 2015, pp. 65–76.
(9) Cho Chung-un, «Itaewon Once Again at Center of Virus Fears», The Korea Times, 16 June 2020, https://www.koreatimes.co.kr/southkorea/globalcommunity/20200616/korea-encounters-itaewon-once-again-at-center-of-virus-fears.
(10) Hunam Yun, «Translation and Fragmented Cities: Focus on Itaewon, Seoul» (see note 4), p. 46.
(11) Kim Eunjeong, «We 'Decide,' You 'Expedite': Imperial Directives for Housing Development in South Korea, 1954–59», Architectural Theory Review 28, no. 3 (2025), pp. 444–472, here p. 456, https://doi.org/10.1080/13264826.2025.2459947.
(12) Korea Economic Institute of America, «A Conversation on USFK's Move from Yongsan to Camp Humphreys», 2020, https://keia.org/the-peninsula/a-conversation-on-usfks-move-from-yongsan-to-camp-humphreys/.
(13) Special Act on the Creation of Yongsan Park, Korea Legislation Research Institute, https://elaw.klri.re.kr/eng_service/lawView.do?hseq=51658&lang=ENG.
(14) West 8, «Yongsan Park», project page, https://www.west8.com/projects/yongsan-park/.
(15) Jung Hae-yong, «South Korea Launches New Yongsan Park Overhaul, Targets 2027 Plan», ChosunBiz, 12 February 2026, https://biz.chosun.com/en/en-realestate/2026/02/12/G65TMETMFREO7OKDFMKN5T4E4U/.
(16) Ibid.
(17) West 8, «Yongsan Park» (see note 14); the site area is given as 243 hectares, approximately 600 acres, in earlier West 8 documentation, and as 750 acres on the firm's current project page.
(18) Ben Jackson, «Truth of Contamination at U.S. Military's Yongsan Garrison Begins to Emerge», Korea Exposé, 2017. https://koreaexpose.com/south-korea-yongsan-garrison-contamination/.
(19) Sébastien Marot distinguishes a rhetorical mode of design, which imposes a predetermined vision on a site regardless of its history, from a mnemonic mode, which reads a landscape's accumulated memory as the basis for intervention. I borrow this distinction to describe what I call performative reclamation: a design that presents itself visually as a mnemonic reading of the site's memory, while its underlying structural imbalances remain unaddressed. Sébastien Marot, Sub-urbanism and the Art of Memory, London 2003, pp. 30–42, here p. 30.
(20) «Itaewon Class», JTBC television series, 2020, distributed by Netflix, https://www.netflix.com/kr-en/title/81193309.

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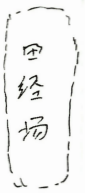
trans is a semi-annual journal managed by an independent student editorial team, addressing current issues in the realm of architecture from a variety of perspectives since 1997.

For trans 49, let us turn to the left and plunge our feet into the evil, the fragile, the leftover, the alternative – the other side. Left is many directions – What is Left of you? What is Left to you?



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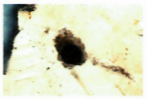

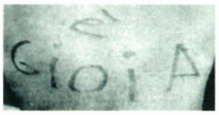

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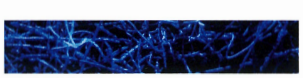

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